STRATEGIC COMMUNICATIONS
INSIGHT SERIES

Executive Media Relations Checklist

Preparing leaders to communicate with clarity, confidence and strategic purpose.

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Introduction

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Media engagement is not simply about answering questions. It is an opportunity for leaders to shape understanding, strengthen trust, and demonstrate organisational purpose.

Executives today operate in an environment where every interview, statement, and public appearance contributes to organisational reputation. This checklist helps leaders and communication teams prepare for meaningful media engagement.

Why this resource matters

In a high-stakes corporate landscape, unstructured communication presents a significant reputational liability. This framework transforms media appearances from reactive Q&A sessions into deliberate opportunities to project institutional narrative and secure stakeholder alignment.

Who Should Use It

- Chief Executive Officers and C-Suite Executives
- Corporate Affairs Directors and Communications Professionals
- Board Members and Designated Institutional Spokespersons

How to use this resource

Before every major media engagement, utilize this checklist to rigorously assess executive and narrative readiness.

Executive Reflection: Core Intent

Before proceeding to the operational sections, sit with your team and address these foundational strategic questions:

- Are we communicating because we have something important to say, or simply because we have been asked?
- Are our messages aligned with our organisation’s strategic priorities?
- Are we prepared to communicate clearly under pressure?

Use this space to outline the specific context, timeline, and nature of the upcoming media engagement.

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STRATEGIC PREPARATION

SECTION 1: DEFINE YOUR COMMUNICATION OBJECTIVE

Complete this diagnostic assessment prior to confirming or building content for any media engagement.

Strategic Diagnostic Questions	Verification/Notes
What is the purpose of this engagement?	
What outcome do we want to achieve?	
Who are we trying to reach?	
What should stakeholders understand after this conversation?	
How does this support organisational goals?	

Light bulb moment 

A media interview is not the objective. The objective is what changes after the interview

SECTION 2: BUILD YOUR MESSAGE FOUNDATION

Do not rely on improvisation. Ensure your communication team has verified, stress-tested, and documented the core message architecture below.

Three Key Messages

Message 1:

Message 2:

Message 3:

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- [ ] Supporting Evidence or Examples:

- [ ] Relevant Organisational Stories:

- [ ] Data Points or Proof of Impact:

- [ ] Responses to Difficult Questions:

Strategic tip

The strongest messages are not always the most complicated. They are the ones people remember.

EXECUTION & STAKEHOLDER ALIGNMENT

SECTION 3: EXECUTIVE READINESS CHECK

Verify that the designated spokesperson has been thoroughly briefed on the structural dynamics of the specific engagement.

- [ ] Understand the Audience: Clear alignment on demographic, expectations, and biases.
- [ ] Understand the Media Outlet: Deep understanding of the journalist's style and platform stance.
- [ ] Review Likely Areas of Interest: Clear mapping of potential editorial angles.
- [ ] Practise Explaining Complex Issues Simply: Translation of technical data into accessible insights.
- [ ] Identify Sensitive Topics: Established boundaries and defensive messaging paths.
- [ ] Confirm Approved Facts and Figures: Absolute verification of all metrics and data.
- [ ] Align with Organisational Values: Guaranteeing the tone matches corporate identity.

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SECTION 4: STAKEHOLDER AWARENESS

Consider how different target groups may interpret, dissect, or react to your public statements.

Stakeholder Group	Key Concerns/Expected Reactions	Risk Mitigation Level
☐ Employees		Low/Med/High
☐ Customers		Low/Med/High
☐ Investors		Low/Med/High
☐ Regulators		Low/Med/High
☐ Communities		Low/Med/High
☐ Industry Partners		Low/Med/High
☐ Media Audiences		Low/Med/High



Reflection

Which stakeholder group requires the most communication attention right now?

POST-ENGAGEMENT DEBRIEF & CLOSING

SECTION 5: AFTER THE ENGAGEMENT

The work does not conclude when the cameras turn off. Run a post-engagement analysis within 24 hours of release.

- ☐ Was the Intended Message Understood? Evaluate the final editorial cut or print against core messages.
- ☐ What Feedback Emerged? Document internal and external commentary.
- ☐ Did New Concerns Appear? Track secondary narrative risks or spin-off queries.
- ☐ What Should Improve Next Time? Assess technical delivery, pacing, and preparation loops.

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Executive Reflection

What communication capability does our leadership team need to strengthen

PARTNER WITH EIGHTPLUS MEDIA

Strong communication does not happen by accident. It requires meticulous preparation, intentional strategy, and absolute corporate alignment.

Eightplus Media works with modern organisations to strengthen executive communication capability, safeguard corporate reputation, and deepen stakeholder confidence. We anchor long-term commercial and social trust through structured advisory support, crisis simulation frameworks, and tailored executive programmes.

Beyond the Checklist: Exploring Strategic Alignment

If your organization is ready to transition from reactive communication to proactive, strategic influence, we invite you to connect with our advisory team for a collaborative evaluation. Let’s map out how your leadership's communication architecture can reliably drive your broader institutional goals.

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